

SALES PIPELINE & REVENUE DASHBOARD

Project Discussion Brief | Excel + Beginner Power BI

Project purpose: Build a simple business dashboard that turns raw sales-opportunity data into clear answers about revenue, pipeline health, conversion, lead sources and where potential sales are being lost. The project is designed to demonstrate practical business analysis and reporting rather than advanced coding.

1. Project Overview

The project uses a simulated sales or CRM dataset, cleaned and analyzed in Excel, then visualized in a beginner-friendly Power BI dashboard. It is meant to replicate a common business situation: a company has sales data, but management does not have a simple, consolidated view of what is driving revenue or where opportunities are being lost.

Core business question: How can a company use its sales data to understand pipeline performance, identify lost revenue opportunities, and decide where sales teams should focus their time and resources?

2. Business Problem the Project Addresses

Many companies collect large amounts of sales information through spreadsheets or CRM systems. The problem is not always a lack of data; it is often a lack of visibility. Data may exist across records, but decision-makers still have difficulty turning it into quick, useful answers.

- Sales managers cannot immediately see how much revenue is being generated and from which sources.
- Leads and deals may be sitting in the pipeline without clear visibility into where they are getting stuck.
- Marketing or sales teams may continue investing in lead sources that generate volume but weak conversion.
- Different reports may use different numbers, definitions or time periods, making performance difficult to compare.
- Teams may focus on activity levels rather than the business outcomes that matter: conversion, revenue, deal value and sales velocity.

3. Causes Behind These Business Issues

- Fragmented data: sales information may be stored in multiple spreadsheets, CRM exports or manually maintained trackers.
- Manual reporting: recurring reports can be time-consuming and prone to inconsistent calculations or copy-paste errors.
- Too much raw data, not enough interpretation: teams may track hundreds of records without a concise KPI view.
- Limited pipeline visibility: without stage-level analysis, it is difficult to identify where opportunities are slowing down or dropping out.
- Weak linkage between lead source and revenue: companies may know where leads came from without knowing which sources actually produce closed business.
- Lack of decision-ready reporting: data may be technically available but not presented in a format managers can use quickly.

4. Gaps the Project Fills

Gap	How the project responds
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Visibility gap	Consolidates revenue, conversion and pipeline KPIs into one dashboard.
Pipeline gap	Shows where deals sit by stage and where drop-off or delays may be occurring.
Revenue attribution gap	Connects lead sources, customer segments or sales channels with actual revenue outcomes.
Performance comparison gap	Makes it easier to compare time periods, reps, channels or customer groups consistently.
Decision-making gap	Turns raw records into charts, KPIs and business insights that can support resource allocation and follow-up priorities.
Communication gap	Provides a visual summary that managers can understand without reviewing hundreds of spreadsheet rows.

5. Questions the Dashboard Can Answer

Revenue & growth

- How much revenue has been generated this month, quarter or year?
- Is revenue increasing or decreasing over time?
- What is the average deal value?
- Which customer segments or channels contribute the most revenue?

Pipeline health

- How many active opportunities are currently in the pipeline?
- What is the total value of open opportunities?
- Which pipeline stages contain the most deals?
- Where are deals slowing down or dropping out?

Conversion

- What percentage of leads become won deals?
- Which lead sources have the strongest conversion rates?
- Which stages have the largest drop-off?
- Are high-volume lead sources also producing high-value customers?

Performance

- Which sales reps or channels are generating the most revenue?
- Who has the strongest conversion rate or average deal size?
- Are some teams generating many deals but lower-value business?

Planning

- Where should sales teams focus follow-up effort?
- Which lead sources may deserve more or less investment?
- Which stages need process improvement?
- What customer groups appear most valuable to target?

6. Issues the Analysis Could Identify

The goal is not only to display charts. The analysis should identify business patterns that could trigger action. Depending on the simulated dataset, examples could include:

- A high number of deals entering the pipeline but a low overall conversion rate.
- A specific stage where opportunities consistently stall or are lost.
- Lead sources that generate many prospects but little closed revenue.
- A smaller lead source that produces fewer opportunities but stronger conversion or larger deals.
- Customer segments with high average deal value but longer sales cycles.
- Large differences in performance across sales reps or channels.
- Months with unusually weak pipeline creation that may affect future revenue.
- Old opportunities remaining open for too long, reducing confidence in the reported pipeline.

7. Practical Uses for a Company

- Weekly or monthly sales performance reviews.
- Sales-manager pipeline meetings and follow-up prioritization.
- Revenue forecasting discussions using open pipeline value as an input.
- Marketing and sales alignment around lead-source quality.
- Identifying process bottlenecks in the sales funnel.
- Comparing performance across products, customer segments, regions, channels or sales representatives.
- Providing leadership with a concise view of commercial performance without requiring them to inspect raw data.

8. Suggested Dataset Structure

A simulated dataset of approximately 300-500 sales opportunities is sufficient. It should feel realistic but remain manageable for a beginner project.

Field	Example	Why it matters
Opportunity ID	OPP-001	Unique record identifier
Created Date	2026-01-15	Tracks pipeline creation over time
Closed Date	2026-02-08	Enables sales-cycle analysis
Lead Source	Referral / Website / Event	Compares source quality
Sales Stage	Qualified / Proposal / Negotiation	Shows pipeline position
Deal Value	\$7,500	Measures revenue and pipeline value
Outcome	Won / Lost / Open	Measures conversion
Sales Rep	Rep A	Compares performance
Customer Segment	SMB / Mid-market	Identifies valuable segments
Industry	Retail / Services / Tech	Adds business segmentation

9. Key Metrics to Calculate

- Total closed revenue
- Number of won deals
- Number of lost deals
- Open opportunity count

- Open pipeline value
- Win / conversion rate
- Average deal value
- Revenue by month
- Revenue by lead source
- Conversion by lead source
- Deals by pipeline stage
- Revenue by customer segment
- Average sales cycle length (optional)

10. Skills Put to Use

Excel

- Data cleaning and formatting
- Tables and filters
- PivotTables and PivotCharts
- SUMIF / SUMIFS and COUNTIF / COUNTIFS
- XLOOKUP or VLOOKUP where needed
- Date calculations and basic formulas
- Conditional formatting
- Basic data validation and error checking

Power BI - beginner level

- Importing an Excel dataset
- Creating KPI cards
- Building bar, column, line and funnel-style visuals
- Adding slicers or filters
- Arranging a clear dashboard layout
- Using simple calculated fields only where necessary
- Communicating insights visually

Business and analytical skills

- Defining business KPIs
- Turning a business problem into measurable questions
- Interpreting trends rather than only presenting data
- Identifying bottlenecks and performance gaps
- Customer and sales segmentation
- Commercial awareness
- Presenting findings and recommendations to non-technical stakeholders

11. Recommended Dashboard Layout

A one-page dashboard is enough. Keeping it simple will make the project easier to explain and more credible.

- Top KPI cards: Total Revenue | Open Pipeline Value | Win Rate | Average Deal Value
- Chart 1: Revenue by Month
- Chart 2: Opportunities by Pipeline Stage
- Chart 3: Revenue or Conversion by Lead Source
- Chart 4: Won vs. Lost Deals
- Chart 5: Revenue by Customer Segment or Sales Rep

- Filters: Date, Sales Rep, Lead Source, Customer Segment

12. Example Findings and Recommendations

These are illustrative examples only. The final conclusions should be based on the dataset actually used.

Type	Example
Finding	Referral leads account for a smaller share of total leads but a larger share of closed revenue.
Possible recommendation	Increase focus on referral programs or investigate what makes referral leads higher quality.
Finding	A large percentage of opportunities remain in the proposal stage for more than 30 days.
Possible recommendation	Introduce a follow-up cadence or aging report for stalled proposals.
Finding	One segment has strong conversion but a lower average deal value.
Possible recommendation	Use a separate sales approach for high-volume, lower-value customers rather than evaluating all segments the same way.

13. Step-by-Step Build Plan

1. Create or download a realistic sales-opportunity dataset and keep the scope to roughly 300-500 rows.
2. Clean the data in Excel: remove duplicates, standardize stage names, check dates and ensure deal values are numeric.
3. Define 5-8 core KPIs before building charts.
4. Use PivotTables and formulas in Excel to verify the numbers and explore patterns.
5. Import the cleaned Excel table into Power BI.
6. Build a simple one-page dashboard with KPI cards, 4-5 charts and a few filters.
7. Write 3-5 business insights based on the dashboard.
8. Add 2-3 realistic recommendations linked directly to the findings.
9. Prepare a short project summary and screenshots for a portfolio, GitHub or interview discussion.

14. What Makes the Project Valuable on a Resume

- It proves practical use of Excel rather than only listing Excel under skills.
- It introduces Power BI at a realistic beginner level without relying on advanced SQL or Python.
- It demonstrates understanding of the full commercial funnel: leads -> opportunities -> conversion -> revenue.
- It connects naturally with experience in sales, financial services, CRM records, customer workflows and operations.
- It gives a concrete example to discuss when interviewers ask about data analysis, KPI reporting or business problem-solving.
- It can support applications across Business Analyst, Operations Analyst, Sales Operations, Revenue Operations, Customer Success and Implementation roles.

15. Resume Positioning - After the Project Is Completed

Suggested project title: Sales Pipeline & Revenue Dashboard | Excel, Power BI

- Analyzed 500+ simulated sales opportunities using Excel to track revenue, conversion rates, deal stages and customer segments.
- Created an interactive Power BI dashboard displaying sales performance, pipeline trends, lead-source performance and key revenue metrics.

Important: the wording should only be used after the project has genuinely been completed and should match the actual dataset, calculations and dashboard created.

16. How to Explain It in an Interview or Discussion

A strong short explanation would be:

“I wanted to build a project around a business problem I could realistically encounter in sales or operations. I used a simulated CRM dataset to analyze revenue, conversion and pipeline performance in Excel, then created a simple Power BI dashboard so a manager could quickly see where revenue was coming from, where deals were getting stuck and which lead sources were performing best. The main focus was not advanced coding; it was turning raw sales data into useful business decisions.”

17. Scope and Credibility

- Use simulated or public data; do not present it as confidential data from a former employer.
- Keep the project beginner-friendly and make sure every formula, chart and KPI can be explained confidently.
- Avoid adding SQL, Python or advanced analytics unless they are actually used and understood.
- Do not claim that a recommendation caused real-world revenue growth unless the project was implemented in a real business and measured.
- The strongest version of the project is simple, accurate and explainable rather than technically complicated.